West by North-West: Ancient India until 700 CE

India has been continuously inhabited since pre-historic times, first by early human relatives (hominids) and later by *homo sapiens*. Hominid remains have been discovered in the Narmada Valley and Tamil Nadu. Plentiful Palaeolithic tools associated with early human populations have been found throughout the country, and petroglyphs (rock art) have been preserved in places like Bhimbetka. Around 12,000 years ago, early Indian villages and settlements emerged in what is now Rajasthan, Ladakh, Madhya Pradesh, the Ganga River Valley, and the Deccan, with evidence of agriculture and domestication of animals.

From nomadic life and early villages, human communities in India began to witness growth into cities. The earliest evidence of urban developments in India is associated with the Harappan culture, which peaked between about 2600 and 1900 BCE. Prominent examples include sites such as Lothal, Rakhigarhi, and Dholavira in today's India as well as in Mohenjo-Daro and Harappa in what is today Pakistan. The Harappan culture provides some of the earliest evidence of trade between India and other regions. Harappan artefacts such as seal inscriptions, ivory, and carnelian beads have been found in modern Oman, the United Arab Emirates, Bahrain, Iraq, and Iran, indicating maritime trade networks up to Mesopotamia. By land, Harappan exports extended to present-day Turkmenistan, while commodities such as jade, tin, and lapis lazuli were imported. Trading posts were established in places like Shortughai in northern Afghanistan. [4]

The Vedic cultures that followed after around 1500 BCE provide us with the earliest decipherable Indian historical records, including religious, mythological and political texts in Sanskrit, Pali, vernacular Prakrits and Tamil, among other languages. These were often recounted orally or written on palm leaves (*talapatra*) and are complemented by archaeological finds, inscriptions, coins, and other such materials. A common theme in much of the surviving literature involves matters of governance, war, and peace. The Rig Veda, for example, details warring tribes, victorious kings, and battles. Politics and warfare are, of course, central to the Ramayana and